

How High Desert Works

The whole thing, in a neighbor's words

HIGH DESERT · REDMOND, OREGON

High Desert is a small, member-owned place for your town's life online, a nonprofit no one can buy or sell — verified neighbors, no ads, no algorithm deciding what you see. Here's how it actually works, start to finish.

GETTING IN

You join by showing you actually live here. There are a few ways — a photo of an ID or a utility bill, voter registration, a property record, or a code we mail to your address — and a real person checks it, not a bot. The moment you're verified, **we delete the proof**. We don't keep your documents; we just needed to know, once, that you're a real neighbor. Then you pick your neighborhood (Redmond is mapped into about thirty-five) — a filter, not a fee — and if none fit, a person follows up.

WHAT YOU DO HERE

Events. Anyone verified can post a neighborhood gathering, say who's coming, and note what they're bringing. No comment pile-ons, no "trending" — just what's happening, soonest first. **And early in year one, a local exchange** — arriving with the first all-member votes: mutual aid and skill-sharing, offers and asks among neighbors, with no payments inside, no star ratings, no cut taken, and never an ad against any of it.

HOW DECISIONS GET MADE

The community runs itself by vote. Anyone can put up a proposal; everyone votes; the ballot is secret until voting closes, so no one can lean on you. Your vote counts a little more the longer you've been a member — between one and three times — which rewards showing up over time without creating a ruling class. And every decision can be revisited later; nothing is permanent by accident.

WHEN SOMETHING GOES WRONG

If a moderator takes something down, they have to say why, in writing — and you can appeal it. A **different** moderator hears the appeal, so no one is judge of their own call. Nothing ever just quietly disappears. It's the same due process you'd want anywhere with real stakes. Sanctions are graduated — a warning before any timeout, never a permanent ban without board review — and if neighbors believe a call was wrong, sustained complaints put it to a community vote.

THE MONEY

It's a flat couple of dollars a month for verified residents, and the price can't go up without the members voting for it. Anything taken in beyond what it costs to run goes to local charities the members pick by vote each year, and the founder's pay comes from those same dues and is published for everyone to see, every quarter.

YOUR DATA

Your data is yours. You can export it, take it, or delete it and leave. It is never sold, and there are no ads — because the people paying the couple of dollars are the owners, not the product.

Small on purpose, legible on purpose, and built to stay that way.

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